

OSINT REPORT: WIKIPEDIA / WIKIMEDIA FOUNDATION

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What This Is

A simple, plain-language OSINT (open-source intelligence) summary of Wikipedia — how it started, how it works, who runs it, and what's happening to it now. All information comes from public sources only: the Wikimedia Foundation's own website, Wikipedia itself, and news reporting.

How Wikipedia Started

Wikipedia grew out of an earlier, failed project called Nupedia (2000), where experts wrote and reviewed articles one by one. That process was extremely slow — Nupedia produced only about a dozen articles in its first year. In January 2001, Jimmy Wales and Larry Sanger launched Wikipedia as a quicker “side project”: instead of expert review, anyone could write or edit an article instantly using simple wiki software.

- It worked almost immediately: Wikipedia had over 20,000 articles within its first year — Nupedia never got past a few dozen.
- Nupedia quietly shut down in 2003; Wikipedia had completely overtaken it.
- The Wikimedia Foundation was created in 2003 to own and run the servers and organization behind Wikipedia.
- English Wikipedia passed 1 million articles in 2006, 2 million in 2007, and now has more than 7 million; the encyclopedia as a whole (all languages) has passed 65 million articles.

How Wikipedia Actually Works

A few simple ideas explain almost everything about how Wikipedia runs day to day:

- Anyone can edit. No account or credentials are required to fix most pages (though some sensitive pages are protected from editing to prevent vandalism).
- Volunteers, not staff, write and edit almost all the content. The Wikimedia Foundation runs the technology and organization; it does not write or approve articles.
- “Neutral point of view” is the core rule: articles are supposed to describe topics fairly, without taking sides, and every claim should be backed by a published, reliable source.
- Nearly 250,000 people make at least one edit in a typical month, adding up to roughly 13 million edits a month across all of Wikipedia — about 5 edits every second.
- Mistakes and vandalism do happen, but the open-editing model means errors usually get caught and fixed quickly by other volunteers.

Milestones Timeline

Year	Milestone
2000	Nupedia launches as a slow, expert-reviewed encyclopedia
Jan 2001	Wikipedia launches as a faster, open-editing “side project” of Nupedia

Year	Milestone
2001	First non-English editions launch (German, French, Catalan, Swedish, Italian); 20,000+ articles by year-end
2003	Nupedia shuts down; the Wikimedia Foundation is created to run Wikipedia
2006	English Wikipedia reaches 1 million articles
2007	English Wikipedia reaches 2 million articles; Wikipedia becomes a top-10 U.S. website
2016	The Wikimedia Endowment is launched as a permanent long-term fund
2020	Wikimedia Enterprise launches, offering a paid data feed for large commercial users
2024–2025	AI chatbots and search summaries begin visibly cutting into human traffic, even as AI-training bot scraping surges
Jan 2026	Wikipedia turns 25; Bernadette Meehan becomes the Foundation's sixth CEO

The Wikipedia Family (Sister Projects)

Wikipedia is the best-known project, but the Wikimedia Foundation runs several related ones, all built on the same free, editable model:

Project	What it is
Wiktionary	A free dictionary and thesaurus
Wikiquote	A collection of quotations
Wikibooks	Free, collaboratively written textbooks
Wikimedia Commons	A shared library of free images, video, and audio (144M+ files)
Wikinews	Collaborative, volunteer-written news
Wikidata	A structured, machine-readable database of facts used across all the projects
Wikiversity / Wikivoyage	Free learning materials / an editable travel guide

Snapshot: Wikipedia Today

Question	Answer
Who runs it?	The Wikimedia Foundation, Inc. — a U.S. nonprofit (501(c)(3)) based in San Francisco
How big is it?	65+ million articles in 300+ languages; 7+ million in English alone
Who writes it?	Volunteers — nearly 250,000 active editors a month, worldwide
How popular is it?	Consistently one of the ten most-visited websites in the world
How is it funded?	Mostly small donations from individual readers

Money

The Foundation spent \$190.9 million in the 2024–2025 fiscal year. Spending grew more slowly than usual (7% vs. its typical ~15% a year), partly because it cut costs like office space. Almost 80% of its budget goes directly to supporting Wikipedia and its volunteer communities.

- Mostly funded by small individual donations, collected through on-site banners and email campaigns
- A newer paid service, Wikimedia Enterprise, sells high-volume data access to big companies (including AI firms); it brought in \$8.3 million this past year — small, but growing fast (+148%)
- By policy, that commercial revenue is capped at 30% of the Foundation's total income, specifically to keep Wikipedia's independence from large corporate funders
- A separate long-term savings fund, the Wikimedia Endowment, is worth about \$169 million
- Financial audits have been clean for 20 straight years — no red flags there

Leadership

Bernadette Meehan became the Foundation's new CEO on January 20, 2026, the sixth person to hold the role since 2006. She's not a tech industry veteran — she was previously the U.S. Ambassador to Chile and, before that, ran global leadership programs at the Obama Foundation. The Board of Trustees picked her partly for her diplomacy background, expecting she'll need it to navigate AI-related disruption and rising regulatory attention to Wikipedia's content.

The Big Problem: AI

This is the most important thing happening to Wikipedia right now.

- Fewer people are visiting Wikipedia directly — human traffic dropped about 8% in the past year, because AI chatbots and AI-generated search answers now just repeat Wikipedia's content instead of sending people to the site itself.
- At the same time, AI companies are aggressively scraping Wikipedia's text and images to train their models. This has pushed bandwidth costs up 50% since 2024, and these bots now cause about 65% of the site's most expensive server traffic, despite being only around a third of total visits.
- In short: AI relies heavily on Wikipedia's content, but sends fewer humans back to it. That matters because Wikipedia depends on human visitors for both donations and new volunteer editors — lose the visitors, and eventually you risk losing the people who keep the encyclopedia accurate and up to date.

The Foundation's response is to push AI companies toward paying for a proper data feed (Wikimedia Enterprise) instead of scraping for free, and to ask AI tools and search engines to link back to Wikipedia more often.

Other Risks Worth Knowing

- Legal costs are rising as the Foundation defends Wikipedia and its volunteers in courts in different countries
- Some critics have long questioned why the Foundation keeps growing its savings/endowment instead of spending more directly on the website itself
- Wikipedia isn't currently being sued over AI training data the way many news publishers are, but it sits at the center of the industry-wide AI-copyright debate since so many AI models were trained heavily on its content

- A handful of governments (including China, Iran, and Russia) have blocked or restricted access to Wikipedia at various times; the UK's Online Safety Act has also raised the possibility of new restrictions, which the Foundation has said it may not comply with

Bottom Line

Wikipedia's underlying organization is financially healthy, transparently run, and has weathered 25 years of growth from a scrappy side-project into one of the internet's most-visited sites. Its real challenge today isn't money or leadership — it's that AI is quietly replacing the reason people visit the site directly, even while depending on Wikipedia's content to function. How that tension resolves over the next year or two is the thing most worth watching.

Sources: wikimediafoundation.org, meta.wikimedia.org, Wikipedia, and news coverage from Engadget, Search Engine Journal, Gizmodo, HISTORY.com, and others. Compiled from public information only.